THE B-17 TAIL GUNNER CONTINUED TO FIGHT, EVEN AFTER BEING SHOT DOWN

THE STORY OF GENE MORAN WHO FELL 4 MILES IN A B-17 TAIL THAT WAS SEPARATED FROM THE REST OF THE PLANE AND LIVED TO BECOME A POW

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Gene Moran posing in uniform in 1943, the same year his plane was shot down

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On November 29, 1943, tail gunner Eugene Paul Moran survived what could have been a horrific crash aboard a Boeing B-17 Flying Fortress. While on a bombing run over Germany, his aircraft was shot at and broke in two. Normally, there'd be no survivors to speak of, certainly not the tail gunner. However, Moran survived the incident, against all odds. This is the truly unbelievable story of how your average tail gunner survived being shot down by the enemy.



US Air Force / National Museum of the US Air Force

Eugene Moran was born on July 17, 1924, in Wisconsin, and was working on his family's farm near Soldiers Grove at the outbreak of World War II. He enlisted in the US Army Air Forces (USAAF) following the Japanese attack on Pearl Harbor, which acted as the impetus to serve his country, instead of shoveling horse manure.

Like so many others, Moran had just turned 18 upon his enlistment in October 1942. Following training, he was assigned to the 96th Bombardment Group, 339th Bombardment Squadron, Eighth Air Force.

Now in the fight, Moran became a tail gunner aboard a B-17 Flying Fortress, nicknamed “Rikki Tikki Tavi” after the mongoose in the Rudyard Kipling novel, *The Jungle Book*. He, along with nine other crewmen, were stationed at RAF Snetterton Heath, flying daytime bombing runs over Germany



THE CREW

On November 29, 1943, *Rikki Tikki Tavi* was joined by other B-17s of the Eighth Air Force, enroute to Bremen, Germany. After successfully dropping their payload over the city, *Rikki Tikki Tavi* fell behind the other bombers and became the singular target for the German defenses.

The B-17 was hit from the air and ground. ***Eight crewmen were killed, leaving Eugene Moran and the bomber’s navigator as the only ones still alive***. *The latter, located in the forward section of the aircraft, successfully bailed out*. ***Moran, on the other hand, was stuck in the tail***.

As if that wasn’t bad enough, things were about to get even worse. Before he could do anything, German flak successfully hit *Rikki Tikki Tavi*, ripping it apart. The tail section, from just in front of the vertical and horizontal stabilizers, remained intact. Moran, in a desperate attempt to survive, tried ***to open a hatch to bail out; however, it wouldn’t open***.

Luckily, the tail section hadn’t been forced downward as violently as the rest of the B-17. Staying relatively upright, *Rikki Tikki Tavi*’s tail acted as a glider.

Moran and the rest of *Rikki Tikki Tavi*‘s crew had only completed four missions when disaster struck.

For most people, survival would have been their priority. With that out of his hands, Eugene Moran continued to fight until he reached the ground. He fired his two M2 Browning machine guns at the *Luftwaffe*-flown Messerschmitt Bf-109s that continued to attack him. Seeing a seemingly unknown aircraft above, the German flack batteries also continued firing at Moran.

A few moments later, the tail section of *Rikki Tikki Tavi* glided down to earth, stopping abruptly when it flew into a tree. Moran was alive but badly injured. He was bloodied and had a cracked skull from when his head was thrown against his machine guns upon impact. He’d also sustained broken ribs and forearms. Moran was attended to by two Serbian prisoners of war (POW), who were doctors. They’d seen the crash and rushed to help.

Luckily, the American tail gunner went on to make a full recovery. That being said, he wasn’t out of the woods. Over 17-18 months, Moran was moved to different POW camps in Germany, Russia and Poland, and also survived a 600-mile march between February and April 1945.

On April 26, 1945, Moran, weighing only 128 pounds, was liberated by his fellow Americans in Bitterfeld, Germany. Upon his return to the United States, he was awarded two Purple Hearts, the Air Medal with Gold Leaf Cluster, the Good Conduct Medal and the European Theater Award.



Soldiers Grove Gunner Falls 4 Miles In Plane Tail—And Lives!

NEW YORK—(AP)—Trapped in the severed tail of a Flying Fortress, S. Sgt. Eugene Moran of Gays Mills, Wis., fell four miles into a tree top in Germany and lived to become a German prisoner of war, an eyewitness relates. (Moran's home is near Soldiers Grove, the Tribune was told today.)

Moran's escape with only minor injuries was described by S. Sgt. George C. Fisher, of Rosindale, Mass., one of 218 wounded and 21 American soldiers repatriated by the exchange ship Gripsholm and interviewed at Halloran hospital.

It happened last Nov. 29, Fisher said, after the tail cut off the plane tail, with Moran, the tail gunner, caught inside. Moran couldn't jump because his parachute had been shot full of holes, so he folded the chute around him and waited for the inevitable.

Stabilizer Hits Tree

As the tail dropped earthward, the damaged vertical fin and horizontal stabilizers fluttered and flapped, Fisher said, breaking the speed of the fall. Then, one of the stabilizers stabbed into the tree—and held.

Fisher said that he saw the plane tail fall and lodge in the tree as he floated to earth after bailing out of a plane which had been hit on a bombing mission over Bremen. After he was captured, Fisher said, he heard the Germans talk about "a soldier found in the tail of the plane," and later heard Moran's story when the two men became friends in the prison camp.

Moran's one regret, Fisher said, was for hoping when he returned to the United States with the almost unbelievable story, similar to the experience last April of another tail gunner, Sgt. James A. Ruley of Henderson, Ky., who fell more than three and one-half miles in a Fortress tail section and landed in a tree top in the Italian area.

Fisher said he promised to vouch for Moran's story.

Sgt. Moran is the son of Mr. and Mrs. Joseph Moran, who live in the West Fork community about five miles from Soldiers Grove. His parents received word that he was missing in December, 1943. Notification that he was a prisoner came Jan. 21, 1944.

Sgt. Moran entered service Oct. 16, 1942 and trained at Jefferson Barracks, Mo., Las Vegas, Nev., and Lowery Field, Colo. He went to England Oct. 19, 1943.

He lived until March of 2014, having fathered nine children with his beloved wife Peg, and died at the age of 92. They sang his favorite hymn at his funeral—"The Old Rugged Cross".



Gene Moran in 2011

Of the approximately 120,000 American airmen who died in the war, historians believe only three men who fell without parachutes from such a height survived, and the only full-length detailed story that has been recorded is that of Eugene Moran, the farm boy from Wisconsin who couldn't wait to get off the farm and into the fray.

His Obituary …. ***A tribute to a local legend***

Decorated veteran and Soldiers Grove resident, Eugene Moran passed away at the age of 89 on March 23, 2014.

Moran was a Crawford County native and enlisted in the U.S. Army Air Corps in 1942.

As a tail gunner in a B-17 Flying Fortress, on his fifth bombing mission, his plane encountered heavy fire near Bremen, Germany. The tail section of his plane was severely damaged and separated from his aircraft during combat. With a bullet-riddled parachute, Moran rode the tail section down at a rate of

100 feet per second, according to the narrative in a Veterans Lifetime Achievement Award he received in 2007.

Moran sustained a crushed skull when the section he was riding hit a tree before crashing to the ground. He was saved by a Serbian doctor who was also a POW and performed surgery to repair his head wounds.

Moran remained a prisoner of war for nearly 18 months. Incarcerated in POW camps in Germany, Prussia, and Poland. He survived solitary confinement, relocation on a 'hell ship' on the Baltic Sea, and a 600-mile forced march from early February to late April in 1945, during one of the harshest winters on record.

Eugene was liberated in late April of 1945, weighing only 128 pounds. He was discharged December first. He was awarded two Purple Hearts, the Air Medal with Gold Leaf Cluster, the European Theater Award, and the Good Conduct Medal. Eugene was also the first recipient of the prestigious Veterans Lifetime Achievement Award from the Wisconsin Board of Veterans Affairs.

In an interview for the Federal Veterans History Project, Moran recalled why he enlisted.

"Well, when I was a kid there on the farm, on a nice bright day I would be lying here and looking up at the sky and see those planes, and I always said someday I'll be in one of them, and I did."

A year after his discharge, Eugene married Margaret "Peg" Finley and moved to Soldiers Grove where they raised nine children. Margaret passed after 57 years of marriage, but Eugene found love once more and married Pauline Montgomery in 2007.

Eugene continued to be a public servant during the years after the war. He was a Life Member of American Legion Post 220 and held several leadership positions and chaired numerous service projects. He served as chief of the Soldiers Grove Volunteer Fire Department, a Charter member of the Soldiers Grove Rescue Squad, and a fire warden for 30 years, and was an active member of St. Philips Parish.

After his over 30-year career as a rural mail carrier, Gene served as a member of the Crawford County Board of Supervisors for 20 years. In 2008, the Village of Soldiers Grove dedicated a street in the village park, naming it after him to honor him.

Gene was said to have lived his life to the fullest and embraced as his life's philosophy "I'd rather wear out than rust out."



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